Schwarz at his apartment. For his efforts, the professor spent three months in prison, lost his job and was ultimately expelled to the Federal Republic in 1986.

Though embarrassing for Honecker, Chancellor Helmut Schmidt was equally roused, fearing the document would endanger the policy of détente. Once scorned, as he considered he had been, Honecker began planning a campaign against foreign journalists operating within the GDR.

The brutal winter of 1978–9 – one of the worst in living memory – left the GDR shivering in the lowest temperatures for two decades. On 28 December 1978, a 72-hour snowstorm in the north cut-off the Baltic Island of Rügen, leaving ill-equipped and ill-prepared emergency services flummoxed. As the bitter weather tightened its grip, the entire country sank into total darkness on New Year's Eve when lignite opencast mines plunged to minus 20°C, leading to the collapse of the power supply. (One of the main causes of this predicament was a 1976 decision to convert all electricity and heating supplies to lignite-based fuels.)

Amid this turmoil, Erich Honecker jetted off for an official visit to India. Under Asian skies, he was bedazzled by the boisterous reception in New Delhi.3 The trip got underway with a wreath-laying at the Mahatma Gandhi memorial, followed by a whistle-stop tour of Agra and Bombay to inspect industrial, scientific and merchant shipping concerns. Of immeasurably greater moment was his place on the podium alongside Prime Minister Morarji Desai, who nodded in agreement as Honecker denounced the apartheid policy of South Africa and expressed support for the 'just struggle' against colonial oppression.4

On his return to Germany, the US Ambassador to the GDR, David Benjamin Bolen, noted the considerable amusement among diplomatic observers about the presence of the interfering Soviet Ambassador Pyotr Abrasimov, at the airport for both the departure and arrival of Honecker. 'While Abrasimov's presence can be explained, in part, by the fact that Honecker stopped briefly in Tashkent,' a top-secret cable stated, 'the general explanation is that Abrasimov's presence demonstrates, once again, Moscow's dominant role in GDR foreign policy. We have also been told by diplomatic colleagues that their East German contacts were asking,